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Culture (OWC): [Lozi \(FQ09\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date

1940-1942, 1947 (Lozi); 1936-1938 (Zulu)

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Section Title(S)

KINSHIP STRUCTURE AND THE AFFILIATION OF CHILDREN

This merging also extends to the spouse's relatives in lower and higher generations. People whom your spouse calls 'child' or 'grandchild' or 'grandparent' or 'great-grandparent' are similarly related to you, and you may not marry them. You primarily distinguish your parents- and children-in-law by the self-reciprocal term *mukwenyani*, but you also call them respectively 'father' and 'mother' and 'child', and your spouse's more distant connexions, such as mother's brother, you address by the same terms as your spouse does. His or her siblings, irrespective of sex, are *balamu* (sing, *malamu*), or husband (w.s.) or wife (m.s.), again irrespective of their sex. Beyond that a man or woman takes over the terms of address which his or her spouse uses for kinsfolk.

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Thus among the Lozi relationships in all lines of descent tend to be merged by generations. The actual importance of the different lines varies from individual to individual, with a general bias to the paternal. But the mother's immediate home is more important than the home of someone distantly connected in the patrilineal line. Nearness of cognatic relationship, and not membership of a unilineal kin-group, is emphasized. There are slight differences in the behaviour patterns to father and mother's brother, and to mother and father's sister, but in general they are similar. Father and mother's brother are both treated with affectionate respect, but the relationship is easier with the latter. However, while among the Southern Bantu a man may claim something he wants from his mother's brother, among the Lozi a man could take anything of his father's or mother's brother's or of any other relative (*kufunda*: this has now been declared their). A man can claim help from his mother's brother as from his father, and father and mother's brother share marriage payment of girls equally. My impression is that generally a man is

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friendlier with, and takes more care of, his sister's children than his brother's children. The father's sister is treated with considerable respect, while people behave with more ease to mother's sister.

There is one variation in behaviour to parents' siblings of the same and different sexes. A mother's brother also calls his sister's daughter 'my wife' and his sister's son 'my fellow-husband' (*mufubalume*), and father's sister also calls her brother's son 'my husband' and her brother's daughter 'my co-wife' (*muhalizo*), as well as 'my child'. Grandparents and grandchildren of opposite sex can address each other similarly. Between persons of opposite sex this form of teasing ceases when the youngsters, who find it embarrassing, grow up: they use the terms grandparent, father, mother, and child, out of respect. But mother's brother and sister's son still call each other 'fellow-husband' because the nephew can sleep in his uncle's hut, fondle his uncle's wife's breasts, and marry her if she wants to when his uncle dies. Lozi also say that these terms are  177 used because these relationships are friendly and easy, and the youngsters can consult their elders on sexual matters (e.g. about the impotence of niece's husband or frigidity of nephew's wife); but clearly they fall into the pattern of joking relationships, since we have here a woman who is a father, and a man who is a mother. Similarly in the case of grandparents there is conflict because the terms of nomenclature identify odd and even generations despite the great difference in age.

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